PETSBUZZ

# PUPPY'S FIRST 30 DAYS

## Your puppy is home. Now what?



## THE FIRST MONTH, IN THE ORDER YOU'LL ACTUALLY LIVE IT.

House training. Socialization. Sanity. In 30 days.

PetsBuzz / Narristotle

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# Before We Start

This book is for the first month. Not the first year, not the whole life of the dog. Just the thirty days when everything is new, nothing is routine yet, and you're running on less sleep than you planned.

I wrote it the way I wish someone had written it for me: short chapters, in the order things actually happen, with the numbers and the mistakes left in. If a chapter tells you to do something, it also tells you what goes wrong when you don't, because I did most of those things wrong the first time.

Two things to know up front. First, nothing here is vet advice. When your puppy's health is on the line, your vet is the authority, and this book will say "ask your vet" whenever that's the right answer. Second, your puppy doesn't need a perfect owner. They need a consistent one. Same times, same words, same rules, every day. That's most of this book, honestly. The rest is details.

**How to use this book.** Read it in order the first time, because the chapters follow the puppy's first month the way you'll actually live it. After that, use it like a reference. Something goes wrong with house training, go back to chapter three. The puppy won't stop biting, chapter nine. You're not sure whether to call the vet, chapter eleven. Each chapter ends with a short "do this today" list, so if you only have five minutes, read that and do it. The appendix at the back holds the first-week checklist, the potty log, the first-month milestones, the vet questions, and a first-aid kit list. Photocopy the potty log. You'll want a fresh one every week. The whole book is about sixty pages, short enough to read in an evening, and you'll get more out of it if you read it before the puppy arrives than after. But if the puppy is already home and already chewing the table leg, start at chapter nine. That's fine too.

Let's get into it.

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# Chapter 1: Before Day One

The puppy comes home on Saturday. It's Tuesday. You have four days, and the pet store would love to sell you four hundred dollars of stuff before Saturday gets here. Most of it can wait.

Here's the short list. This is what you actually need on day one.

**The crate.** Get one with a divider panel. Your puppy needs room to stand up, turn around, and lie flat. They don't need room to run a marathon in there. If the crate is too big, they'll sleep at one end and pee at the other, and then you've taught them the crate is a bathroom. The divider fixes that. You slide it back as they grow. A 36-inch crate with a divider covers most medium breeds from puppyhood to adult. A Lab or a German Shepherd will need the 42-inch. A Chihuahua will laugh at the 36-inch. Buy for the adult size, divide for the puppy size.

**Food.** Ask the breeder or the shelter what the puppy is already eating, and buy that exact food. Not the food you researched. Not the food with the nicest bag. The food their stomach already knows. You can switch foods later, slowly, over a week. Switching on day one is how you get diarrhea on day two, and you will blame the puppy when it was the food.

**Bowls.** Two stainless steel bowls, one for food, one for water. Stainless cleans easy and doesn't hold smells. Skip the plastic. It scratches, it holds bacteria, and some puppies chew it into pieces.

**A leash and a collar.** A flat collar with a tag that has your phone number on it. A six-foot leash, not a retractable one. Retractable leashes teach a puppy that pulling makes the leash longer, which is the exact opposite of what you want. The six-foot leash is boring and it works.

**Poop bags.** A lot of them. A roll on the leash, a box by the door, a stash in the car. You will use more than you think.

**Enzyme cleaner.** Not regular cleaner. Enzyme cleaner. Regular cleaner takes the smell away for you. Enzyme cleaner breaks down the stuff that tells a puppy "this is the bathroom spot" so they don't go back to the same square foot of carpet forever. Nature's Miracle is the one most people can find anywhere. Get the big bottle.

**A few chew toys.** A Kong, a rope, something rubbery. Not ten toys. Three. Puppies get overwhelmed by a toy box the same way toddlers do, and a puppy with three toys learns what they're allowed to chew faster than a puppy with thirty.

**Treats.** Small, soft, smelly. The size of a pea. Zuke's Minis are the standard for a reason. You will go through hundreds of these in the first month, so buy the big bag.

That's the list. Everything else — the fancy bed, the raincoat, the puzzle feeders, the subscription box — can wait until you know your dog.

**What not to buy (yet).** The pet store will try to sell you a lot of things on day one, and most of them are for a dog you don't have yet. The fancy bed is a good example. Puppies chew beds. They pee on beds. They drag beds around the room. Buy a cheap towel for the crate now and a nice bed in three months, when the puppy has stopped treating furniture like food. Same with the raincoat and the booties. Your puppy will outgrow them in six weeks, and most puppies hate wearing them anyway. Wait until you know your dog's adult size and whether they even like going out in the rain.

The puzzle feeders and the slow-feeder bowls can wait too. They're great tools, but a puppy who is still learning to eat regular meals doesn't need a puzzle. They need a bowl and a schedule. The subscription box is the easiest no of all. You don't know what size your puppy will be, what they like to chew, or what they're allergic to. A box of random

toys and treats is a box of guesses, and you're paying for the guessing. Buy the short list now. Buy the rest when you know who you're buying for.

**What the first month costs.** Nobody tells you this before you get a puppy, so here it is. The short list in this chapter runs about a hundred to a hundred and fifty dollars: the crate is the big piece, forty to eighty dollars depending on size, and the rest is bowls, leash, collar, cleaner, toys, and treats. Food runs about forty to sixty dollars a month for a medium puppy, more for a large breed, less for a small one. The first vet visit with the first round of shots runs a hundred to two hundred fifty dollars, and the full vaccine series across three visits runs three to five hundred total. Flea, tick, and heartworm prevention runs about thirty to fifty dollars a month once it starts. A puppy class runs a hundred to two hundred dollars for a six-week course, and it's the best money you'll spend in the first month. All in, budget five hundred to eight hundred dollars for the first month, not counting what you paid for the puppy. It's a lot. It's also the cheapest month, because the second month has the same food and prevention costs without the crate and the first vet visit. Plan for it now and it won't surprise you later.

**Puppy-proofing.** Get down on the floor. Seriously. Lie on your stomach in the living room and look around at puppy height. Every cord, every shoe, every remote control, every houseplant is now a chew toy. Puppies explore with their mouths. They don't know what a laptop charger is. They know it fits in their mouth and it feels interesting.

Move the cords behind furniture or cover them. Put shoes in the closet. Move the plants up high or out of the room. Check the plant list before you decide which ones are safe, because some common houseplants will make a puppy genuinely sick. Lilies, sago palm, and oleander are the ones to know by name. If you have them, they go outside or they go away.

**Puppy-proofing the yard.** The yard needs the same treatment as the house, and people forget it because the yard feels like outside, and outside feels safe. Walk the fence line before the puppy ever goes out alone. Look for gaps at the bottom where a small puppy can squeeze through, and look for spots where the fence meets the house, because that's where the gap usually is. A puppy who can fit their head through a gap can fit their whole body through it. Check for anything the puppy can eat. Mushrooms grow fast after rain, and some of them are poisonous. Fertilizer and weed killer sit on the grass for days after you spread them, and a puppy who licks their paws after walking on a treated lawn is eating chemicals. Keep the puppy off treated grass for at least a few days, and read the label on anything you spread. If you have a pool, a pond, or a steep drop anywhere in the yard, block it off. Puppies don't know how to swim until they learn, and they don't know a pool is different from a water bowl until they're in it. A puppy should never be in the yard alone for the first month. You're out there with them, every time, until you know the yard and the puppy both.

Baby gates are worth more than any training book. One at the stairs, one blocking off the room you don't want the puppy in yet. A puppy with the whole house on day one is a puppy having accidents in rooms you forgot existed. Start small. One room, then two, then the house. The puppy earns space by not having accidents in it.

**Picking a vet.** Do this before the puppy arrives, not after something goes wrong at 9 p.m. on a Sunday. Call two or three clinics near you and ask three questions. Do you take new puppies? What does a first visit cost? And what are your emergency hours? The answers tell you most of what you need. A clinic that answers the phone and quotes a straight price is a good sign. You want a vet who'll see your puppy within the first week home. Most breeders and shelters require that first visit within 72 hours anyway, and it's in the contract more often than people realize.

**First-night setup.** Decide now where the puppy sleeps, because changing it on night three is harder than picking right on night one. The crate goes in your bedroom. Not the kitchen, not the laundry room, not down the hall. Your bedroom. A puppy alone in a new house at night is scared, and a scared puppy cries, and a crying puppy in the kitchen at 2 a.m. is a puppy you will give up on and bring into bed, and then you've got a dog in your bed for the next fifteen years. The crate next to your bed means they can hear you breathe. It means you can hear them stir when they need to go out. It means everyone sleeps more.

Put a worn T-shirt of yours in the crate. Not a new blanket. Your shirt, the one you slept in. It smells like you, and smell is the sense a puppy trusts most right now.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Buy the short list. Move the cords and the shoes. Call the vet and book the first visit. Put the crate in your bedroom. The rest can wait.

# Chapter 2: The First Night

Nothing prepares you for the first night. You can read about it, people can warn you, and at 2:47 a.m. you'll still be sitting on the bedroom floor wondering what you've done.

Here's what the first night actually looks like. The puppy goes in the crate around 10 p.m. They cry. Not a little whine. A full, heartbroken howl, like you've locked them in a dungeon. This lasts somewhere between ten minutes and an hour. Then they sleep. Then around 1 or 2 a.m. they stir, and you take them out. They pee. You put them back. They cry again, shorter this time. Then morning.

That is a good first night. If that's how yours goes, you're doing fine.

**The crying.** A puppy cries at night for two reasons: they need something, or they're lonely. You have to figure out which one, fast, because the answer is different. Need-something crying sounds urgent and it doesn't stop. They need to pee. Take them out. Lonely crying sounds sad and it fades in and out. They need to know you're there. Put your fingers through the crate door. Talk quietly. Don't take them out for lonely crying, or you teach them that crying gets them out of the crate, and then crying is their job forever.

The rule that saves people here: if the puppy has been quiet for an hour and suddenly starts crying hard, that's a bathroom cry. Get up. If the puppy has been crying on and off since you put them in, that's a lonely cry. Stay in bed, put your hand near the crate, and wait it out. It gets shorter every night. Night one is the worst. Night three is half as bad. By the end of week one, most puppies walk into the crate on their own.

**The 3-3-3 rule.** Someone who fosters rescue dogs came up with this, and it holds for new puppies too. Three days to decompress. Three weeks to learn the routine. Three

months to feel at home. Your puppy spent their first weeks with their mother and their littermates. Then a car ride, a new house, new smells, new sounds, and you. Three days of that is a lot. Don't expect a normal dog on day two. Expect a tired, confused baby who needs food, sleep, and a bathroom schedule. The personality shows up around week three. The real dog shows up around month three.

**Sleep.** Puppies sleep a lot. Eighteen to twenty hours a day at eight weeks old. That's normal. A puppy who sleeps all afternoon and then has a wild hour at 8 p.m. is not broken. That's the schedule. The wild hour even has a name. Trainers call it the witching hour. It usually hits in the evening, right when you're trying to eat dinner. The puppy runs laps, bites the rug, bites your ankles, and acts possessed. It passes. It always passes. Tire them out before it starts with a short training session and a chew toy, and the witching hour gets shorter.

**When the crying doesn't stop.** Most puppies settle within a few nights. But some don't, and if yours is still crying hard on night five, there's usually something you can change. First, check the obvious. Did they go to the bathroom right before bed? A puppy with a full bladder will cry until you let them out, and they're right to cry. Did they eat dinner too late? A puppy fed at 9 p.m. will need to go out at 2 a.m. Move dinner earlier and the midnight trip moves earlier too.

Second, check the crate. Is it in your bedroom, where they can hear you? A crate down the hall is a lonely place for a puppy who spent their whole life sleeping in a pile of warm bodies. Move the crate next to the bed. If you already did that and they're still crying, try a warm water bottle wrapped in a towel, tucked in the crate. It feels like a littermate. Some puppies settle the first night you try it.

Third, check yourself. Are you getting up every time they make a sound? If you rush over at the first whine, the puppy learns that whining brings you running, and then

whining is their job. Wait a minute. Listen to the kind of crying. A puppy who is working themselves up needs you. A puppy who cries for thirty seconds and then settles was testing the system, and you staying in bed just taught them that the crate is safe and you're nearby. That lesson is worth more than the sleep you lose while they learn it.

If none of that works and the puppy is still crying for hours every night after a week, call your vet. It might be pain, it might be anxiety, and either way you want a professional's eyes on it.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Keep the first night boring. Same crate, same spot, same bedtime. When they cry, check the clock before you check the puppy. An hour of quiet followed by hard crying means bathroom. Crying since bedtime means lonely. Stay close, stay calm, and remember that night one is the hardest night there is.

# Chapter 3: House Training

House training is the thing new owners worry about most, and it's the thing with the simplest answer. Take the puppy out a lot. Reward them when they go outside. Don't punish them when they go inside. That's the whole method. The rest of this chapter is the schedule and the mistakes.

**The schedule that works.** A puppy's bladder holds for about one hour per month of age, plus one. An eight-week-old puppy can hold it for roughly two to three hours when they're awake. When they're asleep, a little longer. That number is your schedule.

Take them out first thing in the morning, right when they wake up. Take them out after every meal. Take them out after every nap. Take them out after every play session. Take them out before bed. And take them out every two hours in between. That's a lot of trips outside. In the first week, you'll lose count. That's normal. A puppy who goes out twelve times a day has twelve chances to get it right.

Go to the same spot every time. The same patch of grass, the same corner of the yard. Puppies go where they've gone before. The smell tells them what the spot is for. Stand there, be boring, and wait. Don't walk them around the block hoping they'll go. Don't play with them. Stand in the spot, look at the sky, and give them a minute. When they go, say your word. Some people say "go potty." Some people say "hurry up." Pick one phrase and use it every time. Then praise them like they just won something. A treat, a happy voice, a little celebration. The puppy needs to know that going outside is the best thing they did all day.

**Crate training.** The crate is your best tool for house training, and it works because of one fact: dogs don't like to soil where they sleep. A puppy in a right-sized crate will hold it longer than a puppy loose in the house, because the crate feels like a den. That's

why the divider matters. Too much room and the den becomes a house with a bathroom at the far end.

The crate is never a punishment. Never shove a puppy in the crate because you're angry. Never leave a puppy in the crate for hours because you don't want to deal with them. A puppy who hates the crate will bark, panic, and pee in it. A puppy who likes the crate will walk in on their own by week two. Make it good in there. Meals in the crate. Treats in the crate. The good chew toy lives in the crate. The door stays open during the day at first so they can wander in and out. You close it for naps and for bedtime, and you open it the second they wake up and carry them straight outside.

**Accidents without drama.** Your puppy will have accidents in the house. Probably today. Probably on the rug you like. Here's what you do: nothing dramatic. If you catch them in the act, make a short sound, something like "ah ah," pick them up mid-stream if you can, and carry them outside to the spot. If they finish outside, praise them. If you find the accident after the fact, say nothing at all. Clean it up with the enzyme cleaner and move on.

Don't rub their nose in it. That doesn't teach a puppy anything except that you're scary and unpredictable. Don't yell. Don't drag them to the spot an hour later and point at it. A puppy lives in the present. Five minutes after an accident, they have no idea what you're upset about. The only thing that teaches house training is catching the right behavior at the right moment and rewarding it, over and over, until the pattern sticks.

Most puppies take four to six months to be reliably house trained. That's normal. A puppy who is perfect at ten weeks and then has accidents at sixteen weeks didn't forget everything. They hit adolescence and got distracted. Go back to the schedule. Take them out more often. It passes.

**The bell trick.** Some owners hang a bell on the back door and teach the puppy to ring it when they need to go out. It works, and it's worth doing if your puppy is the kind who stands silently by the door and then gives up and pees on the floor. Every time you take them out, touch their paw to the bell first. It takes about a week before they connect the bell to the door. It takes about two weeks before they start ringing it on purpose. It takes about three weeks before they ring it just to go outside and chase a leaf. That's the price of the bell. Most owners decide it's worth it.

**When house training stalls.** Some puppies take longer than others, and there's usually a reason. The most common one is that the puppy has too much freedom too soon. A puppy with the run of the house will find a quiet corner and use it, and you'll find it three days later. The fix is to shrink their world again. Back to one room. Back to the crate between outings. Back to the two-hour schedule. It's not a punishment. It's a reset, and it works in about a week.

The second most common reason is that the schedule slipped. You were taking them out every two hours, then life got busy, then it was every three hours, then the accidents started. Go back to the schedule. Set a timer on your phone if you have to. Every two hours, out the door, same spot, same word.

The third reason is a medical one. If a puppy who was doing well suddenly starts having accidents every hour, or strains to pee, or has blood in the urine, call the vet. Urinary tract infections happen in puppies, and they're easy to treat once you know. A puppy who suddenly can't hold it isn't being bad. They're telling you something hurts.

And if your puppy is doing great during the day but still has accidents at night at four months old, that's normal too. Nighttime control comes last. Keep the last water bowl an hour before bed, take them out right before you turn the lights off, and give it time. Most puppies are dry overnight by five or six months.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Write down the schedule. Out on waking, out after meals, out after naps, out after play, out before bed, and every two hours between. Same spot, same word, treat every time they go. Clean every accident with enzyme cleaner and say nothing about it.

# Chapter 4: The First Vet Visit

Book the first vet visit for the first week home. Most breeders and shelters put it in writing: the puppy needs a vet check within 72 hours. Even if nobody requires it, do it anyway. That first visit does three things. It catches problems early, it starts the vaccine schedule, and it gives you a vet who knows your dog before anything goes wrong.

**What happens at the visit.** The vet weighs the puppy, listens to the heart and lungs, checks the eyes and ears, feels the belly, and looks at the teeth. They'll ask what food you're feeding and how much. They'll ask about the puppy's stool, because stool tells a vet a lot. Bring a fresh sample if you can. I know. Put it in a bag. The vet will thank you, and you'll feel silly for about ten seconds and then you'll be glad you did.

The vet will also talk about parasites. Most puppies have worms. Roundworms, usually, passed from the mother. It's normal and it's fixable. The vet will deworm the puppy and set up a schedule for it. They'll talk about flea and tick prevention and heartworm prevention, and they'll tell you when to start each one. In most of the country, flea and tick prevention starts around eight weeks. Heartworm prevention starts around six to eight weeks too, after a test if the puppy is old enough. Your vet will sort out the timing for your area, because the right schedule depends on where you live.

**Shots.** The core puppy vaccine series is the DHPP, which covers distemper, hepatitis, parainfluenza, and parvovirus. Puppies get it in rounds, usually at 6 to 8 weeks, then again at 10 to 12 weeks, then again at 14 to 16 weeks. Three rounds, three to four weeks apart. The rabies shot comes at 12 to 16 weeks, depending on your state's law. Some states require it at twelve weeks. Some give you until sixteen. Your vet knows your state's rule.

Parvo is the one to take seriously. It's a virus that lives in soil and on sidewalks, and it kills puppies. Until your puppy has had at least two rounds of shots, don't take them to dog parks, pet stores, or anywhere a lot of unknown dogs have been. Your own yard is fine. A friend's yard with healthy, vaccinated dogs is fine. The pet store floor is not fine. This is the hardest rule to follow, because you want to show your puppy the world, and the world is exactly where parvo lives. Wait for the shots. The world will still be there in a month.

**Reading the vaccine record.** After each visit, the vet gives you a record of what was done. Keep it. Take a photo of it and keep the paper too. The record lists the vaccine name, the date, and when the next round is due. The names look like alphabet soup, so here's the translation. DHPP is the core puppy series: distemper, hepatitis, parainfluenza, parvo. Bordetella is the kennel cough vaccine, and your vet will recommend it if your puppy will ever go to daycare, a boarding kennel, or a training class. Leptospirosis is a bacterial disease spread through water and wildlife urine, and the vaccine is recommended in a lot of areas now, especially if you live near woods or water. Canine influenza is the dog flu vaccine, and it's recommended if your puppy will be around a lot of other dogs.

You don't need to memorize any of this. You need to know where the record is, when the next round is due, and which vaccines your vet marked as core for your puppy. Put the next due date on your calendar before you leave the clinic. A missed booster by a week is fine. A missed booster by a month means starting the series over, and nobody wants to pay for that twice.

**What it should cost.** Prices vary a lot by city, so I won't give you a number that will be wrong where you live. But here's how to think about it. A first puppy visit with an exam and the first round of shots usually runs somewhere between a hundred and two hundred fifty dollars, depending on your area and what's included. A full puppy

package, three rounds of shots plus deworming plus the first flea and tick dose, can run three to five hundred dollars total, spread across the visits. Ask for the price before the visit, not after. A good clinic will quote you over the phone. If the price is more than you expected, ask what it includes. Sometimes the higher price includes things the cheaper clinic charges separately, and the totals come out even.

**What to ask.** Bring a list. Vets are used to it, and a list means you won't forget the question that was keeping you up at night. Ask about the food and how much to feed. Ask about the vaccine schedule and when it's safe to go to the dog park. Ask about flea and tick prevention and heartworm prevention for your area. Ask about spaying or neutering and when the vet recommends it. Ask about microchipping if the puppy doesn't already have one. And ask the question you're embarrassed to ask, whatever it is. There is no embarrassing question at a puppy visit. The vet has heard it all, and the question you don't ask is the one that costs you a second visit.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Bring the food bag or a photo of the label. Bring a stool sample. Bring your list of questions. Write down the vaccine dates before you leave, and put the next visit on your calendar in the parking lot.

# Chapter 5: Food & Feeding

Puppies eat a lot, poop a lot, and grow fast. A puppy can double their weight in the first month home. All of that growth runs on food, which is why this chapter matters more than the pet store aisle makes it look.

**What to feed.** Feed the food the puppy was already eating, for at least the first two weeks. I said it in chapter one and I'll say it again here because this is where people get into trouble. They bring home a puppy and immediately switch to the food they researched, and the puppy gets diarrhea, and they decide the new food is bad, and they switch again, and now the puppy has had three foods in five days and a stomach that doesn't trust anything.

After two weeks, if you want to switch, do it slowly. Mix a little of the new food into the old food. Day one, a quarter new and three quarters old. Day three, half and half. Day five, three quarters new. Day seven, all new. If the stool gets soft at any step, go back one step and stay there for two days. A slow switch takes a week. A fast switch takes a day and costs you a week of cleanup.

Pick a food made for puppies, not adult dogs. Puppy food has more calories and more of the nutrients a growing body needs, especially calcium and phosphorus in the right ratio for bone growth. The bag should say "puppy" or "growth" on it. For large breeds, get a large-breed puppy formula. Large-breed puppies grow so fast that the wrong calcium balance can cause bone problems, and the large-breed formulas are made to slow that growth down just enough.

**Reading the food label.** The front of the bag is marketing. The back of the bag is the truth. Turn it over and look for three things. First, the AAFCO statement. It says something like "formulated to meet the nutritional levels established by the AAFCO

Dog Food Nutrient Profiles for growth." If that statement isn't there, put the bag back. AAFCO is the group that sets the nutritional standards, and a food without that statement hasn't been shown to meet them. Second, the first ingredient. It should be a named meat, like chicken or lamb, not a vague word like "meat" or "animal." Third, the feeding guide. It tells you how much to feed for your puppy's age and expected adult weight, and it's the starting point for the amount you worked out by feeling the ribs.

Ignore the rest of the front of the bag. "Grain-free," "natural," "holistic," "premium," none of those words are regulated the way you think they are, and none of them tell you whether the food is good. The AAFCO statement tells you. The ingredient list tells you. The puppy's body tells you the rest. If the stool is firm, the coat is shiny, and the puppy is gaining steadily, the food is working. That's the only review that matters.

**How much and how often.** Under six months, feed three to four meals a day. Same times every day. A puppy's stomach is small and their energy needs are huge, so small frequent meals work better than one big one. After six months, most puppies drop to two meals a day, morning and evening, and stay there for life.

How much per meal depends on the food and the puppy. Start with the amount on the bag for your puppy's age and expected adult weight. Then watch the puppy, not the bag. You should be able to feel the ribs under a thin layer of fat, but not see them sticking out. If you can see every rib, feed more. If you can't feel the ribs at all, feed less. The bag is a starting point. Your hands are the real measure. Weigh the puppy every week or two at the vet's scale, or pick them up and step on your bathroom scale and subtract your own weight. A growing puppy should gain steadily. If the weight stalls for two weeks, call the vet.

**Water.** Fresh water, available all the time, in a clean bowl. Change it at least twice a day. A puppy drinks a lot, and a dirty bowl is a fast way to an upset stomach. Wash the

bowl with soap and water every day, the same way you'd wash your own glass. The slimy film that builds up in a dog bowl is bacteria, and your puppy is drinking through it.

Don't restrict water to control peeing. People do this, and it's a bad idea. A puppy who can't drink when they're thirsty will drink too fast when they finally get water, and they'll pee more, not less. The only time to pick up the water bowl is an hour before bedtime, and that's to help the puppy sleep through the night, not to punish them. During the day, the water stays down. If your puppy is peeing every twenty minutes and drinking constantly, that's not a training problem. That's a vet question, because excessive thirst can be a sign of something medical.

**Treats that work.** Training treats should be small, soft, and smelly. The size of a pea. The puppy should be able to eat one in two seconds and look at you for the next one. If the treat is big and crunchy, the puppy spends ten seconds chewing it and forgets what they did to earn it. Zuke's Minis, bits of boiled chicken, little pieces of cheese, all work. Keep the treats to less than ten percent of the puppy's daily food. More than that and you're feeding them treats instead of dinner, and the vet will tell you so at the next visit.

**What never to feed a puppy.** Some of this is common sense and some of it isn't. Chocolate is the one everyone knows. Xylitol is the one most people don't. It's a sweetener in sugar-free gum, some peanut butters, and a lot of baked goods, and a small amount can kill a dog. Check the label on any peanut butter you give your puppy. If it says xylitol or birch sugar, it doesn't go near the dog.

The rest of the never list: grapes and raisins, onions and garlic, macadamia nuts, cooked bones, alcohol. And anything with caffeine. Cooked bones are the one that surprises people. Raw bones are a different conversation. Cooked bones splinter, and a splinter in a puppy's gut is a surgery. No cooked bones, ever, from any animal. Table scraps are a

gray area. A little plain chicken or rice is fine. The fatty skin off the roast and the whole plate of leftovers is not. Fatty food gives puppies pancreatitis, and pancreatitis gives you an emergency vet bill and a very sick dog.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Feed the food they came with, three or four times a day, same times every day. Check the peanut butter label for xylitol. Keep treats pea-sized and under ten percent of the day's food.

# Chapter 6: Socialization

There is a window in a puppy's life when their brain is built to meet the world, and then it closes. The window runs from about three weeks old to about fourteen weeks old. By sixteen weeks it's mostly shut. Everything your puppy meets during that window, they file under "normal." Everything they don't meet, they file under "suspicious, possibly dangerous." That filing system lasts for years.

This is why the first month matters so much. Your puppy is eight to twelve weeks old right now. You are standing in the middle of the window. What you do in the next four weeks shapes how your dog reacts to strangers, other dogs, loud noises, and new places for the rest of their life.

**The 5-second rule.** The PetsBuzz piece this week is about meeting new dogs, and the rule in it is the one to use. When your puppy meets a new dog, let them sniff for about five seconds, then move on. Five seconds is enough for two dogs to say hello. Longer than that and the excitement builds, one of them gets pushy, and a friendly greeting turns into a jumping, barking mess. Five seconds, then you call your puppy away with a treat and keep walking. Short and sweet beats long and chaotic every time. This works for people too. A stranger pets the puppy for a few seconds, you thank them, you move on. The puppy learns that new people are nice and brief, not overwhelming.

**People.** Your puppy needs to meet a lot of different people in the first month. Men with beards, women with hats, kids, older people, people in uniforms, people with umbrellas. Puppies who only meet the people in their own house grow up suspicious of everyone else. Take the puppy with you when you run errands. Sit outside a coffee shop and let people say hello. Go to a park and sit on a bench. You don't need to arrange playdates with strangers. You need volume. Ten brief, happy meetings beat one long, intense one.

Kids deserve a special note. Puppies and kids are both unpredictable, and together they can wind each other up fast. Teach the kids the rules. No chasing the puppy. No grabbing the puppy. No squealing and running, because a running, squealing child looks exactly like a toy to a puppy. Let the puppy come to the child, not the other way around. And never leave a puppy and a small child alone together, even for a minute. Not because the puppy is dangerous, but because both of them are still learning how to behave.

**Sounds and places.** The world is loud. Vacuum cleaners, thunderstorms, fireworks, garbage trucks, sirens, hair dryers. A puppy who hears these things for the first time at eight months old will be terrified. A puppy who hears them at nine weeks old, at low volume, with a treat in their mouth, will file them under normal.

Start small. Run the vacuum in the next room while the puppy eats. Play thunderstorm sounds on your phone at low volume while you play with them. Take them to a busy street and sit on a bench and watch the world go by. If the puppy gets scared, don't make a big deal of it. Don't pick them up and soothe them like something terrible happened, because that tells them something terrible happened. Stay calm, give them a treat, and let them watch from a safe distance. Distance is your friend. A puppy can learn to be fine with a garbage truck from thirty feet away. They don't need to be next to it.

**The vet's office counts too.** The vet's waiting room is socialization, and it's free. Your puppy meets the receptionist, the vet tech, the other dogs in the waiting room, the scale, the exam table, and the smell of the clinic, all in one visit. Make it good. Bring treats. Let the receptionist give the puppy one. Let the tech give the puppy one. Ask the vet to give the puppy a treat before they do anything else, so the first thing the puppy learns about the vet is that the vet gives treats. A puppy who likes the vet's office at ten weeks old is a dog who walks in happily at ten years old. A dog who only goes to the vet when

something hurts is a dog who hates the vet, and a dog who hates the vet is hard to examine, hard to treat, and stressed every time they go.

**Other dogs.** Your puppy needs to meet healthy, vaccinated, friendly adult dogs. Not the dog park. Not yet. The dog park is too much, too fast, for a puppy who hasn't finished their shots and hasn't learned dog manners. Start with one calm adult dog you know. A friend's older dog, a neighbor's mellow Lab. Let them sniff for five seconds, then move on. A good adult dog will teach a puppy more in ten minutes than you can teach in a week. They'll correct a rude puppy with a growl or a turn away, and the puppy will learn faster from that than from anything you say.

Puppy class is the best version of this. A good puppy class is six puppies, a trainer, and a room where they learn to be around each other without chaos. Look for a class that uses positive reinforcement only. If a trainer tells you to dominate your puppy or alpha-roll them, walk out. That's old advice and it's wrong. Your puppy doesn't need a boss. They need a teacher.

**What if my puppy is scared of everything.** Some puppies are braver than others. Some walk into a new room like they own it. Some freeze at the threshold and need ten minutes to work up the nerve to come in. Both are normal, and the fearful puppy isn't broken. They're careful, and careful puppies grow into careful dogs, which is fine, as long as the fear doesn't run their life.

The rule for a scared puppy is distance and choice. Let them watch the scary thing from far away, where they feel safe. Give them a treat for looking at it calmly. Let them decide when to move closer. Never drag a scared puppy toward the thing they're afraid of. Never pick them up and carry them into the middle of it. The puppy needs to learn that the world is safe at their own pace, and your job is to set the pace slow enough that they can keep up.

Watch the body language. A scared puppy tucks their tail, flattens their ears, yawns, licks their lips, and tries to move away. Those are all signals that say "this is too much." When you see them, add distance. Walk the other way. Go back to a place where the puppy relaxes. You haven't failed. You've found the edge of what they can handle today, and tomorrow the edge will be a little further out.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Take the puppy somewhere new and sit on a bench. Let them watch the world for fifteen minutes. Five-second greetings with any dog you meet. One new sound at low volume during dinner.

# Chapter 7: Basic Commands

Training a puppy is not about teaching tricks. It's about teaching your puppy that listening to you pays. Every time your puppy does what you ask and something good happens, they learn that you are worth listening to. That's the whole game. The commands are just the way you play it.

**Five minutes at a time.** Puppy training sessions should be short. Five minutes, two or three times a day. That's it. A puppy's attention span at eight weeks old is about as long as a commercial break. After five minutes, they're done, and if you push past it, they stop learning and start making mistakes, and then you're correcting mistakes instead of teaching. Short sessions, several times a day, beat one long session every time.

End every session on a win. If the puppy just did a perfect sit, give them the treat, tell them they're brilliant, and stop. Don't do one more rep to see if they can do it again. The last thing they remember is the success, and they'll come back to the next session wanting more.

**Sit.** Hold a treat in front of the puppy's nose, then move it slowly up and back over their head. The puppy's nose follows the treat, their head goes up, and their butt goes down. The second their butt touches the floor, say "yes" and give them the treat. That's a sit. Do it five times. Then start saying "sit" right before you move the treat. After a few days, the puppy sits when they hear the word, and you don't need to lure them anymore.

**Come.** This is the most important command your dog will ever learn, and it's the one people mess up the most. The rule for come is simple: coming to you must always be the best thing that ever happened. Every time your puppy comes to you, they get a treat and a party. Every time. No exceptions. And never, ever call your puppy to come and then do something they don't like. Don't call them to come and then put them in the

bath. Don't call them to come and then leave the park. If you do that twice, your puppy will stop coming, and they'll be right to stop, because coming to you became a trick.

Start inside the house. Get down on the floor, open your arms, say "come" in a happy voice, and reward them when they run to you. Then try it from another room. Then try it in the yard. Then try it at the park, on a long leash, when there are interesting things around. Build it up slowly. A puppy who comes running in the kitchen is not the same as a puppy who comes running at the dog park. You have to practice in harder places a little at a time.

**Stay.** Ask for a sit. Hold your hand up like a stop sign. Say "stay." Count to three in your head. Treat. Then build it up. Five seconds. Ten seconds. A minute. If the puppy breaks the stay, don't scold them. Just go back to three seconds and build up again. Stay is a hard command for a puppy because staying still is the opposite of everything a puppy wants to do. Be patient with it. A five-second stay at ten weeks old is a win.

**Leave it.** Put a treat on the floor and cover it with your hand. Say "leave it." The puppy will sniff your hand, paw at it, try to get the treat. Wait. The second they back off, even a little, say "yes" and give them a different treat from your other hand. Never give them the treat that was on the floor. That treat is the one they left. The reward comes from you, not from the floor. Leave it is the command that keeps a puppy from eating chicken bones off the sidewalk, so it's worth the patience.

**Making it stick in new places.** A puppy who sits perfectly in your kitchen and stares at you blankly in the park hasn't forgotten how to sit. They've learned that sit works in the kitchen. Dogs don't generalize the way people do. To a puppy, "sit in the kitchen" and "sit in the park" are two different skills, and you have to teach both of them.

The way to do it is to practice in a new place the same way you practiced in the first one. Start easy. Ask for a sit in the yard. Treat. Ask for a sit on the sidewalk. Treat. Ask

for a sit outside the coffee shop, where there are smells and people and noise. Treat. Each new place is a new lesson, and the puppy gets better at learning new places the more places you practice in. After five or six different places, the puppy starts to get the idea that sit means sit everywhere, and then it clicks.

The same goes for distractions. A puppy who comes running in an empty room and ignores you when a squirrel shows up hasn't learned to come. They've learned to come when nothing interesting is happening. Practice with distractions on purpose, a little at a time. Start with a boring distraction, like a toy on the floor. Then a bigger one, like another person in the room. Then a squirrel, on a leash, from a distance. Each level gets a treat, and the puppy learns that coming to you beats whatever else is going on.

**Positive reinforcement only.** No yelling, no hitting, no spray bottles, no shock collars. None of that teaches a puppy what to do. It teaches them to be afraid of you. A puppy who is afraid of you will obey when you're watching and do whatever they want when you're not. A puppy who trusts you will listen because listening pays. The science on this is settled, and the trainers who still use punishment are selling you something old. Find a trainer who uses food, praise, and patience. Your puppy will learn faster, and you'll both enjoy it more.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Three five-minute sessions. Work on sit, then come, then leave it. End each one on a win. Treat every time, and never call your puppy to come for something they won't like.

# Chapter 8: Walking on Leash

The first walk is a big moment. You've been waiting for it. The puppy has been waiting for it. And then you clip the leash on, step outside, and the puppy either freezes like a statue or pulls like a sled dog. Both are normal. Both are fixable.

**First walks.** Start in the yard, not on the street. Let the puppy wear the collar and leash around the house for a few minutes a day before you ever go outside. Let them drag the leash around the living room while you watch. When they get used to the feeling, pick up the leash and walk around the yard. Treat them for walking near you. Then try the sidewalk in front of your house. Then one block. Then two.

Keep the first walks short. Ten minutes is plenty for an eight-week-old puppy. Their legs are small and their attention is smaller. A ten-minute walk with a lot of sniffing beats a thirty-minute march where the puppy gets tired and scared. Sniffing is the point. A walk is not exercise for a puppy. It's a newspaper. Every smell is a story. Let them read it.

**Pulling.** Puppies pull because pulling works. They pull toward the interesting smell, and they get to the interesting smell, so pulling pays. To fix it, you make pulling stop paying. When the leash goes tight, you stop. You stand still. You wait. The puppy looks back at you, wondering why the walk stopped. The second the leash goes slack, you start walking again. It takes a week of this before the puppy starts to get it. It takes a month before it sticks. It feels slow and it feels boring and it works better than anything else.

Don't use a retractable leash for training. A retractable leash is always a little bit tight, so the puppy never learns what a loose leash feels like. Use the six-foot leash. Hold it with a little slack in it. The slack is the whole lesson. Loose leash means the walk

continues. Tight leash means the walk stops.

**Meeting dogs on leash.** This is where the 5-second rule from chapter six comes back. On leash, greetings are even shorter than off leash, because a leash takes away a dog's ability to walk away when they've had enough. Two dogs on leash who get tangled up in a long greeting can go from friendly to frightened fast, and a frightened dog on a leash has nowhere to go.

Keep it to five seconds. Let them sniff, then call your puppy away with a treat and keep walking. If the other owner wants a longer playdate, that's what the yard is for. On the street, greetings are brief. Your puppy will learn that other dogs are a normal part of the walk, not the whole point of it.

**The first dog park visit.** Wait until your puppy has had at least two rounds of shots before you go. That's usually around twelve weeks. Then pick a quiet time, a weekday morning if you can, when the park isn't crowded. Walk around the outside of the fence first and let the puppy watch the other dogs play. If they seem excited and relaxed, go in. If they seem scared, walk around the block and try another day. There's no rush. The park will still be there next week.

Inside, keep the leash on for the first few minutes. Let the puppy sniff the regulars and get a feel for the place. Then let them off, stay close, and watch. A good first visit is short, fifteen or twenty minutes, and ends while the puppy is still having fun. Leave on a high note. If your puppy gets overwhelmed, if a bigger dog is too rough, if your puppy hides behind your legs, it's time to go. You can always come back. The goal of the first visit isn't to tire the puppy out. It's to teach them that the dog park is a fun place, and that you decide when it's time to leave.

One more thing about dog parks: not every dog belongs there, and that's fine. Some dogs love the chaos. Some dogs would rather play with one friend in a yard. If your

puppy doesn't love the dog park, don't force it. Find them a playmate they like and let them play in a calmer place. A happy dog with one good friend beats a stressed dog in a crowd.

**The witching hour walk.** If your puppy has a wild hour in the evening, take them for a walk right before it starts. A short walk and a training session in the yard will take the edge off. A tired puppy is a good puppy, but a wired puppy is a puppy who needs to move. Ten minutes of walking and sniffing does more than an hour of running around the house.

**DO THIS TODAY**

One ten-minute walk, in the yard or one block. Treat every time the leash is loose. Stop the second it goes tight. Five-second greetings only.

# Chapter 9: Biting, Chewing & Jumping

Your puppy bites you. Not because they're bad. Not because they're aggressive. Because they're a puppy, and puppies explore the world with their mouths, and your hands are in the world. Every puppy owner goes through this. Every puppy owner thinks their puppy is the worst biter that ever lived. They're all wrong. All puppies bite. It passes.

**What's normal.** Puppy biting peaks between eight and sixteen weeks. That's right now. It gets better when the adult teeth come in, around six months. Until then, your hands, your ankles, your sleeves, and your shoelaces are all fair game in your puppy's mind. This is not aggression. Aggression in a puppy this young is rare. Biting is how puppies play with each other. When puppies play, they bite each other, and the puppy who gets bitten yelps, and the biter learns how hard is too hard. Your job is to be the puppy who yelps.

**What to do.** When the puppy bites your hand, make a short, high sound. Something like "ouch" or "yip." Not a scream. Not a lecture. A short sound, and then stop playing. Pull your hand away, turn your body sideways, and be boring for ten seconds. The game stops when the teeth come out. Then offer a toy. When the puppy bites the toy instead of your hand, praise them. You're teaching two things at once: teeth on skin ends the fun, and teeth on toys keeps the fun going.

If the puppy keeps biting after you stop playing, leave the room for thirty seconds. Walk behind a baby gate. Come back, try again. Most puppies figure this out in a week or two. The ones who don't usually have owners who keep playing through the biting because the puppy is cute, and then the puppy learns that biting keeps the game going, which is the opposite of what you want.

**Chewing.** Puppies chew everything. Shoes, furniture legs, remote controls, books, the corner of the rug. Chewing is normal. It's how puppies soothe their gums when they're teething, and it's how they pass the time when they're bored. Your job isn't to stop the chewing. It's to decide what gets chewed.

Give the puppy things they're allowed to chew, and make those things more interesting than your shoes. A Kong stuffed with a little peanut butter and frozen overnight is the gold standard. It takes a puppy twenty minutes to work through it, and by the time they're done, they're tired. A frozen washcloth, wet and twisted and put in the freezer, works for teething gums. Rotate the toys so there's always something new. A toy that's been on the floor for three days is boring. A toy that appears fresh from the cupboard is exciting.

When you catch the puppy chewing something they shouldn't, don't chase them. Chasing turns it into a game, and the puppy learns that stealing your shoe starts the best game in the house. Walk over calmly, offer the right toy, and trade. When they take the toy, praise them. Then put the shoe in the closet where it belongs.

**Teething.** Between four and six months, your puppy loses all twenty-eight baby teeth and grows forty-two adult teeth. The gums hurt, and chewing is how they deal with it. This is the worst chewing phase, and it comes right when you thought the chewing was getting better. It isn't a setback. It's teething.

Cold helps. A wet washcloth, twisted and frozen, gives them something cold to bite. A Kong stuffed with plain yogurt or peanut butter and frozen overnight lasts twenty minutes and soothes the gums at the same time. Ice cubes work too, if your puppy likes them. Some do, some don't. You'll find tiny teeth on the floor during this phase. That's normal. If you find blood on a toy, a little is normal too. A lot of blood, or a puppy who won't eat because their mouth hurts, is a vet call.

**Jumping.** Puppies jump because jumping works. They jump up, they get closer to your face, and someone pets them. The fix is the same as the fix for biting. Jumping makes the good thing go away. When the puppy jumps, turn sideways, fold your arms, and look at the ceiling. Be the most boring person in the room. The second all four paws are on the floor, praise them and pet them. Four on the floor gets the attention. Jumping gets nothing. It takes about two weeks of this before a puppy starts to get it. Guests are the hard part, because guests love being jumped on by a cute puppy, and every guest who pets a jumping puppy undoes a week of your work. Tell your guests the rule before they walk in. Four on the floor, then they can say hello.

**When it's a problem.** Most biting, chewing, and jumping is normal puppy stuff, and it fades with age and training. But there's a line, and you should know where it is. If your puppy growls when you take something away from them, guards their food bowl, or snaps when you touch them, that's not normal puppy biting. That's resource guarding, and it needs a trainer, not a chapter in a book. If your puppy's biting is getting harder instead of softer by four months old, that's worth a call to your vet or a trainer too. Don't wait and hope it goes away. Early help is cheap. Late help is expensive.

**A note on what comes next.** Biting and jumping are puppy problems, and most of them fade. But some puppies grow into dogs whose problem isn't excitement. It's fear. If your puppy barks and lunges at strangers or other dogs, if they hide behind you on walks, if their body goes stiff and their hackles go up when something new appears, that's not the puppy stuff in this chapter. That's fear, and fear grows if you leave it alone. There's a whole guide for that dog, the reactive-dog guide, and it picks up exactly where this chapter leaves off. If what you're seeing looks like fear, not excitement, that's the book you need next.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Yelp and stop the game every time teeth touch skin. Trade for a toy, never chase. Four on the floor gets the petting. And if what you're seeing looks like fear, not puppy excitement, write that down. That's the dog the next guide is for.

# Chapter 10: Alone Time & Separation

Sooner or later you have to leave the house. The puppy has to learn that you leaving is normal, that you always come back, and that being alone is boring, not scary. That lesson takes about a month, and it starts with minutes, not hours.

**Crate vs. pen.** You need a safe place for the puppy when you can't watch them. A crate works for naps and for bedtime. A playpen works for longer stretches during the day, because a pen gives the puppy room to move, a spot to sleep, a toy to chew, and a potty pad at the far end if they need it. A lot of owners use both: the crate inside the pen, door open, so the puppy can choose. The crate is the bedroom. The pen is the apartment. The rest of the house is the city, and the puppy doesn't get the city until they're house trained.

Whatever you use, the rule is the same. The safe place is a good place. Meals happen there. The best chew toy lives there. The puppy goes in there when they're happy, not just when you're leaving. If the only time the puppy goes in the pen is when you walk out the door, the pen becomes the place where you disappear, and the puppy will hate it.

**Leaving the house.** Start with seconds. Put the puppy in the pen with a Kong, walk out of the room, come back thirty seconds later. Do it again. Then a minute. Then five minutes. Then you walk out the front door and come back in two minutes. Build it up slowly over days and weeks. The puppy learns that you leaving is a thing that happens, and then you come back, and nothing bad happened in between.

The biggest mistake people make is making departures and arrivals into a big event. They crouch down, they hug the puppy, they say goodbye in a sad voice, they promise they'll be back soon. Then they come home and make an even bigger fuss. All of that

tells the puppy that leaving is a huge deal. It's not. It's Tuesday. You went to the store. Be boring about it. Pick up your keys, walk out, come back, put the keys down. No speech. No hug. The puppy takes their cue from you. If you're calm about leaving, they learn to be calm about it too.

**How long is too long.** An eight-week-old puppy should not be alone for more than two hours at a time. Not because they'll get lonely, although they will, but because their bladder can't hold it longer than that, and a puppy who has to pee in their pen learns that the pen is a bathroom. At three months, three hours. At four months, four hours. That's the same one-hour-per-month rule from the house training chapter, and it applies here too.

If you work full time outside the house, you need help for the first month. A neighbor, a friend, a dog walker, someone who can come by midday and let the puppy out. There's no way around this. A puppy alone for eight hours is a puppy having accidents, getting bored, and learning bad habits. Budget for the dog walker the same way you budgeted for the food. It's part of the cost of a puppy.

**What if I work long hours.** Some owners can't get home at lunch, and some can't afford a dog walker every day. If that's you, be honest about it and plan around it. A puppy pen with a potty pad at the far end is the fallback, and it's better than a crate for eight hours. The puppy will use the pad, and you'll have a little house training to redo later, but the puppy will be safe and comfortable, and that's what matters most in the first month.

The other option is doggy daycare, but not every puppy is ready for it. A good daycare will tell you if your puppy is too young or too overwhelmed. A bad daycare will take your money and put your puppy in a room with thirty dogs. Visit first. Watch how the staff handles the dogs. Ask how many dogs are in a group and how they separate the

puppies from the adults. If they won't let you watch, that's your answer.

**Separation anxiety basics.** There's a difference between a puppy who doesn't like being alone yet and a puppy with separation anxiety. A puppy who whines for a few minutes when you leave and then settles down is normal. A puppy who panics, drools, destroys the crate, hurts themselves trying to get out, and doesn't stop for the whole time you're gone, that's separation anxiety, and it's a real problem that needs a trainer and sometimes a vet. Don't wait it out. Don't assume they'll grow out of it. Get help early.

For the normal puppy, the fix is the same slow build. Short absences, good things in the pen, calm departures, calm returns. Leave a radio on. Leave a shirt that smells like you. Leave a frozen Kong. And when you come home, wait for the puppy to settle before you let them out. If you rush to the pen the second you walk in, you teach them that your arrival is the most exciting thing in the world, and then your departure is the worst thing in the world. Calm in, calm out.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Practice three short departures. Pen, Kong, out of the room for thirty seconds, back. Then a minute. Then five. Be boring about it every time.

# Chapter 11: Health & Grooming

Your puppy is healthy until they're not, and the difference between a small problem and a big one is usually how fast you notice it. This chapter is about the routine stuff you do every week, the signs that mean "call the vet," and the signs that mean "wait and watch."

**Brushing.** Start brushing in the first week, even if your puppy barely has any coat to brush. The point right now isn't the coat. It's the habit. A puppy who learns that brushing is a calm, pleasant thing that happens a few times a week will let you brush them as an adult. A puppy who never gets brushed until they're six months old and matted will fight you every time.

Brush a few times a week. Short sessions, a couple of minutes, with treats. Use a slicker brush for most coats, a bristle brush for short coats, and a comb for the spots that tangle, behind the ears and under the legs. If you hit a tangle, don't yank it out. Hold the fur at the base so the pulling doesn't hurt the skin, and work the tangle out gently with the comb. If it's a mat that's already tight against the skin, cut it out carefully with blunt-tipped scissors, or ask the groomer to do it. A mat pulled out by force hurts, and a puppy who gets hurt during grooming remembers it.

Baths come when the puppy is actually dirty, not on a schedule. Once a month is plenty for most puppies, and some go longer. Use a puppy shampoo, not your shampoo. Human shampoo is the wrong pH for dog skin and it dries them out. Wet the puppy, lather, rinse well, and dry them with a towel. A puppy who gets a bath every week will have dry, itchy skin, and you'll be treating the problem you caused.

**Nails.** Puppy nails grow fast, and long nails change how a puppy walks. You'll hear them clicking on the floor when they're too long. That's your signal. Trim every two to

three weeks, a little at a time. The rule is to take off the tip, not the whole nail. Inside every nail is a quick, a little blood vessel. If you cut it, it bleeds, and the puppy will not forget it. On white nails you can see the pink quick. On dark nails you can't, so take off a sliver at a time and stop when you see a dark dot in the center of the cut. That's the quick getting close.

If you're nervous about it, have the vet or the groomer show you the first time. Most clinics will do a nail trim for a small fee, and watching someone do it once is worth more than reading about it three times. Keep styptic powder on hand for accidents. It stops the bleeding fast. Cornstarch works in a pinch.

**Teeth.** Puppy teeth are needle sharp and they fall out. Between four and six months, your puppy will lose all twenty-eight baby teeth and grow forty-two adult teeth. You'll find tiny teeth on the floor. That's normal. What's not normal is a baby tooth that won't come out when the adult tooth is already pushing through beside it. That's called a retained baby tooth, and it's common in small breeds. If you see two teeth in one spot, tell the vet at the next visit. They'll decide whether it needs to come out.

Start brushing teeth now, while the puppy is young and tolerant. Use a dog toothpaste, never human toothpaste, because human toothpaste has xylitol or fluoride that dogs shouldn't swallow, and dogs swallow everything. A finger brush works fine for a puppy. A few seconds, a few times a week, is enough to build the habit. Dental disease is the most common health problem in adult dogs, and it starts with plaque you can't see. Brushing now saves you a dental cleaning under anesthesia later, and that cleaning costs hundreds of dollars.

**Ears.** Check the ears once a week. Lift the flap, look inside, and smell. Healthy ears are pink and clean and smell like nothing much. Redness, a bad smell, brown gunk, or a puppy who shakes their head a lot means something's wrong, usually an infection or ear

mites. Don't stick cotton swabs deep into the ear. You can wipe the outer ear with a damp cloth or a vet-approved ear cleaner, but anything deeper belongs to the vet. Dogs with floppy ears get more ear problems than dogs with upright ears, because the flop traps moisture. If your puppy has floppy ears, check them twice a week instead of once.

**The first groomer visit.** If your puppy has a coat that will need regular grooming, a poodle mix, a spaniel, a terrier, anyone with hair that grows instead of fur that sheds, book a groomer visit in the first month. Not for a full haircut. For an introduction. A good groomer will do a puppy's first visit as a bath, a brush, a nail trim, and a lot of treats, and send the puppy home happy. The point is that the puppy learns the groomer's table, the dryer, the clippers, and the sound of the place while they're young and easy to win over. A puppy who meets the groomer at ten weeks old will walk in happily at two years old. A dog who meets the groomer for the first time as an adult, scared and matted, is a dog who hates the groomer forever.

Ask the groomer what they do for a puppy's first visit, and ask to stay and watch. A groomer who won't let you watch is a groomer you don't use. And if your puppy is a breed that doesn't need professional grooming, a short-coated dog like a Lab or a Beagle, you can skip the groomer entirely. A brush, a nail trim, and a bath at home is all they need.

**When to call the vet vs. when to wait.** This is the part that keeps new owners up at night, so here's the line. Call the vet right away if your puppy stops eating for more than a day, has diarrhea with blood in it, vomits more than twice in a day, is lethargic and won't get up, has trouble breathing, eats something toxic, or has a swollen belly. Those are emergencies. Don't wait until morning.

Wait and watch if your puppy has one soft stool and is otherwise eating and playing normally. Wait and watch if they skip one meal but eat the next one. Wait and watch if

they sneeze twice and then go back to playing. Puppies have off hours the same way people do. One soft stool is not a crisis. Three days of diarrhea is. One skipped meal is not a crisis. A puppy who won't eat, won't drink, and won't get up is. When you're not sure, call. Vets would rather answer a question over the phone than see a puppy who waited too long. The call is free. The regret isn't.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Brush for two minutes, check the ears, look at the nails. Write down your vet's phone number and the nearest emergency vet's number, and put them both on the fridge.

# Chapter 12: Weeks 5–12 & Beyond

Thirty days in, you have a different puppy than the one who came home. They know where the door is. They know their name. They sleep through most of the night. They sit when you ask, most of the time. The house feels like theirs now, and you feel like you know what you're doing, most of the time.

Don't get too comfortable. The next phase is coming, and it's the one that catches people off guard.

**Adolescence preview.** Between four and six months, your puppy turns into a teenager. The sweet, eager puppy who listened to everything becomes a dog who hears you, looks at you, and decides whether to listen based on what's more interesting. Commands they knew perfectly at twelve weeks get ignored at twenty weeks. House training regresses. The chewing comes back. The jumping comes back. Owners call the vet in a panic, convinced something went wrong. Nothing went wrong. Their puppy grew up.

Adolescence lasts from about six months to eighteen months, depending on the breed. Small breeds grow up faster. Large breeds take longer. A Great Dane can be an adolescent until they're two. The pattern is the same either way: the dog tests boundaries, forgets training, and pushes for more freedom than they've earned. Your job is to go back to basics without getting frustrated. Shorter sessions, more treats, more patience. The training you did in the first month isn't gone. It's underneath the teenager, and it comes back when the hormones settle.

**The second fear period.** Somewhere between six and fourteen months, many dogs go through a second fear period. A dog who was confident at four months old suddenly gets scared of things they used to ignore. The garbage truck, the man with the hat, the

statue in the park. This is normal, and it's temporary, usually lasting a few weeks. The rule is the same as it was during socialization. Don't force them toward the scary thing. Don't make a big deal of it. Let them watch from a distance, give them a treat, and let them decide when to move closer. Pushing a scared dog toward the thing they're scared of makes the fear worse, not better.

**What changes at 4–6 months.** The baby teeth fall out and the adult teeth come in. The puppy starts losing that soft, round look and gets longer and leggier. The feeding schedule drops from three or four meals to two. The bladder holds longer, and the puppy can go through the night without a bathroom break. The socialization window is closed, but the learning isn't over. A dog keeps learning for their whole life. The window was about what gets filed as normal without effort. After it closes, new things take more work, but they still work.

This is also when most owners start puppy class, if they haven't already. A good class at four to six months old is worth more than a good class at eight weeks, because the puppy is old enough to focus and young enough to learn fast. If you haven't found a trainer yet, this is the time.

**The second month at a glance.** Here's what the next thirty days look like, so nothing in it surprises you. The feeding drops to two meals a day. The vet visit for the next round of shots happens, and the vet says the puppy can go to the dog park now, which feels like a graduation. The puppy starts losing baby teeth, and you'll find them on the floor and wonder if you should keep one. The crate starts to feel small, and you slide the divider back. The puppy starts sleeping through the night without a bathroom break, and you wake up the first time it happens convinced something is wrong. Nothing is wrong. They grew.

The training shifts too. The five-minute sessions get a little longer, and the commands start working in harder places. The puppy learns to walk past another dog without pulling toward it. They learn to wait at the door instead of bolting through it. They learn that the mailman is not an intruder. None of this happens all at once. It happens a little at a time, the same way the first month did, and one day you realize the puppy you brought home is a dog you can take anywhere.

**Your ongoing training routine.** Training doesn't end at thirty days. It changes shape. The five-minute sessions become part of the day instead of a separate event. You ask for a sit before you put the food bowl down. You ask for a wait before you open the back door. You practice come in the yard while the puppy is distracted by a squirrel. The commands move out of the training session and into real life, and that's when they become reliable.

Keep a treat pouch on you for the next few months. Not forever, but for now. Reward the good behavior when you catch it, especially the behavior you didn't ask for. A puppy who chooses to lie down quietly while you eat dinner deserves a treat just as much as a puppy who sits on command. You're rewarding the dog you want to live with, and the more you catch them being that dog, the more they'll be that dog.

**The dog at the end of the month.** Here's what thirty days gets you. A puppy who sleeps in their crate, goes to the bathroom outside most of the time, knows their name, sits when you ask, comes when you call in the house, and trusts you. That's a lot. That's the foundation everything else is built on. The next thirty days will build on it. The month after that will build on that. And a year from now, you'll have a dog who walks next to you, comes when you call at the park, and sleeps at your feet while you work. That dog starts here, in this month, with the schedule and the treats and the patience.

You did the hard part. You showed up every day for thirty days. Keep showing up.

**DO THIS TODAY**

Book the next vet visit. Find a puppy class. Put the treat pouch by the door. And take a photo of your puppy today, because in a month they'll look different, and you'll want to remember this one.

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# Appendix

## First-Week Checklist

This is the lite version. The full printable pack, with the complete first-30-days schedule, the full potty log, and the socialization tracker, is a separate printable. This list covers the first seven days.

**Before the puppy arrives**

- ☐ Crate with divider, set up in your bedroom
- ☐ Food, the exact kind the puppy already eats
- ☐ Two stainless steel bowls
- ☐ Flat collar with a tag that has your phone number
- ☐ Six-foot leash
- ☐ Poop bags, a roll on the leash and a box by the door
- ☐ Enzyme cleaner, the big bottle
- ☐ Three chew toys, one of them a Kong
- ☐ Small soft treats, pea-sized
- ☐ Vet picked, first visit booked within the first week
- ☐ Cords moved, shoes in the closet, plants checked
- ☐ Baby gate up at the stairs

**Day one**

- ☐ First potty trip to the same spot, same word, treat when they go
- ☐ First meal in the crate
- ☐ Collar and leash on for ten minutes inside the house
- ☐ Bedtime in the crate, your worn T-shirt inside, crate next to your bed

### Days two to seven

- ☐ Out on waking, after meals, after naps, after play, before bed, every two hours between
- ☐ Three five-minute training sessions a day, starting with sit and come
- ☐ One new sound at low volume during dinner, one new place from a bench
- ☐ First vet visit done, vaccine dates written down, next visit on the calendar
- ☐ Nails checked, ears checked, first brushing done

## Potty-Log Starter

The log works because patterns hide in plain sight. A puppy who has an accident at 4 p.m. three days in a row isn't being bad. They're telling you 4 p.m. is a bathroom time you missed. Write it down for a week and the schedule writes itself.

Copy this grid for each day. Mark the time, whether they went outside, whether there was an accident, and one note.

| Time | Out? | Went? | Accident? | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 6:00 a.m. | Yes | Pee + poop | | Woke up crying, went straight out |
| 7:30 a.m. | Yes | Pee | | After breakfast |
| 9:00 a.m. | Yes | Pee | | After nap |
| 10:30 a.m. | Yes | | | Sniffed, didn't go, back in 20 min |
| 11:00 a.m. | Yes | Pee | | Went on the second trip |
| 1:00 p.m. | Yes | Pee + poop | | After lunch |
| 3:00 p.m. | | | Yes | Missed the window, rug by the door |
| 3:15 p.m. | Yes | Pee | | Cleaned with enzyme cleaner |
| 5:00 p.m. | Yes | Pee | | After play session |
| 6:30 p.m. | Yes | Pee + poop | | After dinner |
| 8:30 p.m. | Yes | Pee | | Last trip before bed |
| 2:00 a.m. | Yes | Pee | | Woke up crying, straight out and back |

That example is a real first week. Eleven trips outside, one accident, and the accident has a reason: the 3 p.m. trip came too late. The fix isn't a lecture. It's a 2:45 p.m. trip tomorrow. That's what the log is for.

## First-Month Milestones

This is what progress looks like, week by week, so you know whether you're on track. Every puppy is different, and a puppy who hits a milestone a week late is fine. A puppy who misses several of them by a lot is worth mentioning to the vet.

**Week one.** The puppy sleeps in the crate with only one or two wake-ups a night. They eat all their meals. They go to the bathroom outside more often than inside. They know where the food bowl is and where the door is.

**Week two.** The puppy walks into the crate on their own at bedtime, at least sometimes. They sit when you lure them with a treat. They've met ten new people and at least one calm adult dog. The crying at night is down to a few minutes or nothing.

**Week three.** The puppy's name means something. They look at you when you say it. They come to you in the house when you call. They've had their first vet visit and the first round of shots. The house training accidents are down to one or two a day.

**Week four.** The puppy sleeps through most of the night. They sit on the word, not just the lure. They walk on the leash in the yard without pulling the whole time. They've been to three or four new places and heard the vacuum, the hair dryer, and a thunderstorm recording without panicking. They feel like your dog now, not a guest.

## Vet-Visit Questions

Bring this list to the first visit. The questions are in the order that matters most, and each one has a reason.

1. **What food, and how much?** The bag gives a range. Your vet narrows it to your puppy's size and breed.
2. **What's the vaccine schedule, and when is it safe to go to the dog park?** The answer depends on your area and the parvo risk where you live. Don't guess at this one.
3. **What flea, tick, and heartworm prevention do you recommend, and when do we start?** The right product depends on your region, the season, and the puppy's age and weight.
4. **When should we spay or neuter, and does it change for this breed?** The timing isn't the same for every dog. Large breeds often wait longer.
5. **Is the puppy microchipped, and if not, when do we do it?** If the breeder or shelter already did it, get the number and register it in your name before you leave.
6. **What should I watch for in the first month?** Every breed has its own common problems. Your vet knows which ones apply to your puppy.
7. **What's the emergency number, and where's the nearest emergency clinic?** Write both down. You don't want to be searching for them at midnight.
8. **The question you're embarrassed to ask.** Ask it. There isn't one the vet hasn't heard, and the unasked question is the one that costs you a second visit.

## Puppy First-Aid Kit

Keep these in one place, a shoebox or a small bag, so you're not hunting for them when you need them. None of this replaces a vet. It buys you time and handles the small stuff.

- **Styptic powder.** Stops bleeding fast if you nick the quick during a nail trim. Cornstarch works if you don't have it.
- **Saline solution.** For flushing a dirty eye or a small scrape. The kind sold for contact lenses works.

- **Blunt-tipped scissors.** For cutting out a mat or trimming fur away from a small wound.
- **Tweezers.** For ticks. Grab the tick close to the skin, pull straight out, and don't squeeze the body.
- **A clean towel and a blanket.** The towel is for drying a wet puppy and wrapping a shivering one. The blanket is for the car ride to the vet.
- **Your vet's number and the emergency clinic's number.** Written on paper, not just in your phone. Phones die. Paper doesn't.
- **Hydrogen peroxide, 3 percent, unopened.** Only use it if your vet tells you to, to make a puppy vomit after eating something dangerous. Never use it without the vet's say-so, because making a puppy vomit is the wrong move for some poisons.

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# One Last Thing

Thirty days from now, your puppy will be a different animal than the one who came home. They'll know your house, your voice, your schedule, and your smell. They'll trust you. That trust is the whole book, really. Everything else is just how you earn it, one day at a time.

Go take the puppy outside. It's probably time.

# Puppy's First 30 Days

*The New Owner's Guide to House Training, Socialization, and Sanity*

Twelve chapters, 55 pages, written plain. The first month, in the order you'll actually live it: what to buy, the first night, house training, the first vet visit, food, socialization, commands, leash walking, biting and chewing, alone time, health and grooming, and what changes next.

Published by PetsBuzz / Narristotle

This book is not vet advice. When your puppy's health is on the line, your vet is the authority.

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